

Paths Considered, and What Not to Do

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Every bad option here looks cheaper or faster today and costs more later.

Paths we rejected

Tempting path	Why we don't
Put the old app in the cloud as it is	Keeps 4,200 databases and 310 custom copies; cost and tax delays barely move
Rewrite everything by hand	522,000 untested lines won't fit in 12 months; unwritten rules get lost
Bigger servers, one database each	Still 4,200 upgrades per release; cost stays per customer
Just release tax changes more often	Still an engineer per rate change: 4 to 6 weeks, not under 3
A custom copy or plug-in per customer	Brings back 310 builds; one customer's code could reach another's data
Move everyone at once	All 4,200 customers at risk on one night
Old and new live side by side	Two sets of books drift apart
Let AI approve itself or act alone	Unchecked money code; nobody accountable

Traps a reviewer caught in our first draft

- **Capacity versus calendar:** 50 moves a night ignored tax-deadline blackouts.
- **Promises rounded up:** "under 3 weeks" written as 21 days; savings claimed early.
- **Wasted months:** old system kept running when empty; payroll built late.
- **Counting too soon:** one saving twice, freed time as cash, a wave approved early.

Rules of thumb

1. One copy per customer is expensive forever; never keep books in two live systems.
2. Prove numbers to the cent: AI drafts, tools check, people sign.